SMALL-GROUP GUIDE

The Woman Who Ended the War

Jael · Judges 4:1–24

Text: Judges 4:1–24 (with Judges 5; Luke 1:26–45; Colossians 2:13–15; 1 Corinthians 1:26–31) **Big idea:** Jael drove a tent peg through the enemy's head and was called blessed; Jesus let the nails be driven into his hands and made peace for his enemies. **Time:** 60–75 minutes

Before you meet. Read Judges 4 twice, then Judges 5 aloud. Mark the prophecy in 4:9, the rout in 4:15, the tent in 4:17–21, and the blessing in 5:24. Read Luke 1:26–45 and Colossians 2:13–15.

OPEN (5 MINUTES)

Pray. Read Judges 4:1–16 aloud. Ask: "Where do you see God fighting for His people in this passage?"

OBSERVE (15 MINUTES)

1. **The oppression.** What does Judges 4:1–3 tell us about Israel's situation? Why are the 900 iron chariots more than a military problem (4:1–2)?
2. **The call.** What does Deborah say God has already promised Barak (4:6–7)? What does Barak's response reveal (4:8)? Why does God say the honor will go to a woman (4:9)?

INTERPRET (20 MINUTES)

3. **The battle.** Who routs Sisera (4:15)? What do the stars and the torrent add to the story (5:20–21)? Why does Sisera flee on foot?
4. **The tent.** What does Jael say and give to Sisera (4:18–19)? Why is his request in 4:20 so dangerous for her? What does the text leave unexplained about her motives?
5. **The peg.** Read 4:21 and 5:26–27 slowly. How does the song describe the act? What does Genesis 3:15 add to the scene? Why does the text call her blessed rather than merely brave?

APPLY (20 MINUTES)

6. **The outsider.** Jael was a foreign woman with no army. Where do you feel overlooked or underqualified? How does God's choice of her challenge that?
7. **The false peace.** Heber's house had peace with Jabin, but it was built on oppression. Where might we confuse comfort with faithfulness?
8. **The nails.** Read Colossians 2:13–15. What was nailed to the cross? How does the gospel free you from both vengeance and hiding?

CLOSE (5 MINUTES)

Invite each person to finish one sentence: "The war I am still fighting is ____. The victory Jesus has already won is ____." No one has to report it.

Pray: "Lord Jesus, you are the greater deliverer. You did not take a hammer; you took a cross. You did not crush your enemies; you saved them. Forgive us for hiding, for hesitating, and for trying to be the hero. Teach us to use what is in our hands, to trust your victory, and to live as people whose war is over. Amen."

Remind them: the invitation is not "be like Jael." It is "come to the One who took the nail."

LEADER NOTES

- **The oppression.** The cycle of Judges is sin, oppression, cry, deliverance. The chariots are real military technology, but the deeper issue is covenant rebellion (4:1–2).
- **The call.** Barak is named among the faithful in Hebrews 11:32. Do not mock him; his request for Deborah shows a weak faith that still obeys. Deborah's prophecy in 4:9 creates the suspense the chapter resolves.
- **The battle.** The text attributes the rout to the LORD, not to Barak's tactics or the weather. The song's stars and torrent are poetry; do not press them into a meteorological report.
- **The tent.** Jael violates hospitality and her household's treaty with Jabin. The narrator does not explain her motives or soften the act. Hold the moral tension; do not turn her into a simple hero or a villain.
- **The peg.** The violence is real. Do not glamorize it, and do not apologize for the text. The song celebrates God's judgment on an oppressor, not private vengeance. Genesis 3:15 is an echo, not a direct prophecy; keep the typology modest.
- **The gospel.** Jael's peg is a signpost; the cross is the destination. Colossians 2:13–15 is the key: the record of debt was nailed to the cross, and the powers were disarmed. End with the resurrection, not with a call to take up arms.
- **Care.** If anyone discloses abuse, violence, or self-harm, follow safeguarding and connect them to pastoral and professional care. The sermon is not a mandate for revenge (Romans 12:19).